

Q Why is my cesarean-section scar sensitive to touch and painful?

It's normal for your scar to feel tender to the touch while it's healing. You have had a major incision and your body is undergoing the complex job of knitting back together the layers of muscles and fibers to seal the wound.

As the wound site heals, it's common to experience some pain, especially if you move in an awkward way and "catch" your scar. Be careful how you move around. Gradually building up your activity levels will give the wound time to heal. It may not be glamorous, but for comfort, wear big pants (or your partner's boxer shorts). Smaller pants are likely to rub against your scar, causing discomfort.

Aside from the first couple of days after a cesarean section, when even the slightest movement can be extremely painful and you have to make careful, small steps, often with support, the pain should be fairly manageable, albeit with some soreness. If you take your analgesics regularly, you should feel quite comfortable, perhaps experiencing occasional twinges if you overdo things or are especially tired. If after the initial couple of days pain feels extreme, constant, or seems to be getting worse, and if the scar is red and inflamed, be sure to talk to your doctor.

The collagen that makes up scar tissue tends to be less elastic than the original tissue, and when the new collagen fibers form, they often do so in a haphazard fashion, which can cause hardness and restrict movement in surrounding tissues.

Adhesions can also develop, where the scar tissue sticks to surrounding tissues and other organs, which can cause discomfort. Once your scar is well healed, usually at around six weeks, some gentle fingertip massage can help to soften scar tissue, break up adhesions that may be forming, and also improve circulation, which in turn promotes good healing. Rubbing in some vitamin E oil can also help. In addition, a healthy lifestyle will help the incision heal well and reduce discomfort. Gentle walking is perfect exercise after a cesarean section.



Time to heal To begin with the C-section scar, which is usually along the bikini line, will look very red. As it heals, the redness will fade. It is normal to experience some itchiness as the scar heals.

layers of muscle and skin slowly knit back together. As with any major surgery, trying to do too much too soon can set you back. At six weeks, your scar may look fairly well-healed, but there is still internal healing taking place.

If you feel a sharp twinge while attempting something strenuous, such as picking up a heavy bag, it's a sign to rest. Continue to be careful with how you move around, for example get out of bed by rolling onto your side, and avoid lifting heavy weights for two to three months after the birth.

Some women experience pain from trapped gas after a cesarean section. Eat a fiber-rich diet, drink plenty of fluids, and chew food slowly. The trapped air can irritate the diaphragm and cause shoulder-tip pain; drinking peppermint water or peppermint tea can help. While rest is essential, gentle activity is also important for improving circulation, which reduces the risk of conditions such as deep vein thrombosis and also promotes healing.

Q I feel disappointed that the birth didn't go as I'd planned. How can I come to terms with it?

All pregnant women are encouraged to write a birth plan (see p.88), but this may not come to fruition on that day. Events might have unfolded very differently from how you had hoped; you might feel that you lacked control throughout labor, and birth may not have been the joyous occasion that you envisioned it to be. However, with time you will come to terms with your feelings of disappointment.

The best way to deal with your experience and help yourself to resolve any feelings of disappointment or failure is to talk to people about what happened—to your partner, family, and, in particular, the obstetrician. If this doesn't happen before you leave the hospital, make an appointment to speak to him or her at a later date. If you become pregnant again, discuss what happened with your doctor so that you can, if possible, avoid the same experience again. You can also speak to friends about your experience or read online forums. You will soon feel that you're not alone and that it's completely normal to feel disappointed, upset, or even angry at how things went.

Try not to blame yourself or your baby for what took place and speak to your doctor if you are feeling anxious or depressed.



Did you know...

After a C-section, you can begin doing Kegel exercises (see pp.66–67) as soon as you feel ready. If those feel comfortable, you can go for short walks to work your lower abdominal muscles. After six weeks, you can begin light sit-ups, and gentle cycling, walking, or swimming—build your pace up slowly in periods of 10 minutes at a time. Stop if you are in pain and consult your doctor.

Q I'm still getting pains four weeks after my C-section. Is this normal?

It's very common to feel twinges as your body heals. The incisions through your abdominal wall, the underlying muscles, and your uterus understandably need time to join back together. The recovery time varies, but it is often six to eight weeks before you feel back to normal after this major surgery.

Women usually experience an improvement after a few days, but while it becomes easier to move around, there may be considerable tenderness at the incision site as the various